

RUN OUT

As one of the world's most powerful sports impresarios faces the ignominy of being booted out, his own story of delusion and hubris merges with the larger narrative of an unholy alliance of cricket, politics and big business

By Prabhu Chawla and S. Prasannarajan

In the merciless Indian summer, even the most audacious would pause for a while before doing an Icarus. The fatal flaw of the Greek mythological hero was that he was too confident to realise the danger of flying so close to the sun. As Lalit Modi, one of the world's most powerful sports impresarios who soared in the delusion of his own infallibility, hurtles down to the inevitability of infamy, his own story of power and hubris merges with the larger narrative of a national passion play that unites the shirtless and the pinstriped and the khadi-clad. In his final hours as the choreographer of India's biggest sporting spectacle, Modi has become a synonym for the unholy alliance of cricket, politics and business in which everything—honour, morality and transparency—seems negotiable. Today, it is as if his sensational success, worth a few billions, provides the first draft of his obituary.

The name of that success is spelt as IPL, cricket's biggest show on earth. There

is no denying the fact that it is born out of the dream of the 46-year-old Modi whose faith in himself as a man who can never lose the game, no matter whosoever is pitted against him, has already made the Indian Premier League (IPL) a brand worth more than \$4 billion. In three years, it has become the most sought-after platform of vanity fair, where corporate grandees and Bollywood superheroes and investment-savvy politicians jostle for space. Modi was its creator, protector and even its jet-setting brand ambassador, and he played the parts with less flair but with abundant flamboyance. He loved it. The richest and the beautiful swarmed his durbar, and he himself was, miraculously, getting richer—and more arrogant. In the end, as most autocrats drunk on power do, he took leave from the world of accountability and transparency and withdrew himself into the make-believe of immortality. As controversies swirled around him over financial

His 10 Mistakes

- 1 Ran the IPL like a one-man show.
- 2 Antagonised the BCCI general body, whose support he may need to remain in control.
- 3 Made a series of tactical mistakes in handling the Government. Took on Home Minister P. Chidambaram on inadequate security during IPL2.
- 4 Embarrassed the Government on the apparent boycott of Pakistan players by team franchisees in the run-up to IPL3.
- 5 Targeted Shashi Tharoor on conflict of interest using an open forum like Twitter. Put himself and his extended family's interests in IPL firmly in the public glare.
- 6 Isolated himself further by leaking email exchanges between him and other members of the IPL Governing Council.
- 7 Believed he could organise the bids for two new teams on the same principles as the first bid, not realising that by Season 3 everyone wanted a stake in the IPL action.
- 8 Subjected the notoriously secretive BCCI and his biggest backers so far, the team franchisees, to the ignominy of income tax department searches.
- 9 Was naïve enough to believe his alliances with powerful politicians would insulate him from questioning, though his dealings often smacked of cronyism.
- 10 Used the media to talk up his own personality cult as much as the IPL, allowing the glitz, gossip and after-party gatherings to become more symbolic of the property than the actual cricket.